

Feedback Report: ASAPS Modern

Interactive Narrative Authoring Platform (v0.9.28)

Tested on: macOS, March 2026

Tester perspective: Regular user, no prior ASAPS experience

What is Possible

- Build interactive branching stories without writing code, using a fully visual drag-and-drop interface.
- 25+ beat types covering text, dialog, choices, keypads, video, 360-degree panoramas, timers, and more.
- Condition-based branching: the story can check variables, inventory, counters, and visited beats to decide what happens next.
- Inventory system with quantities and character-specific items.
- Built-in keypad/PIN entry with code validation and attempt limits.
- Import stories from Twine (both Harlowe and SugarCube formats).
- Export as standalone HTML: one self-contained file that runs anywhere without a server.
- Multi-language translation support with AI-assisted translation.
- AI-powered beats that generate dialog and content dynamically at runtime (supports Claude, GPT, or local Ollama).
- Fictional time system: an in-story clock that advances as the player progresses.
- 360-degree panorama beats with clickable hotspots for spatial navigation.
- Save/load game state during playback.
- Desktop apps available for both macOS and Windows.

What Impressed Me

- The visual graph editor makes story flow immediately understandable. You can see the entire structure at a glance.
- The KeypadBeat is surprisingly polished: correct code validation, fail routing, attempt limits, all configurable without code.
- The HTML export producing a single self-contained file is great for sharing and distributing stories.
- Having invisible logic beats (SetVariable, ConditionBeat) that you wire into the graph just like visible ones makes complex logic feel approachable.
- The DialogTree supporting nested multi-turn conversations within a single beat is powerful.
- The preview window gives instant playback without leaving the builder.
- Beat types cover a genuinely wide range of interaction patterns, not just text and choices.
- The schema-driven approach means the inspector panel adapts automatically to each beat type without hardcoded UI for every variation.

What Can Be Better

- Steep first-minute experience: opening the tool for the first time, it is not obvious where to start or what to click. A starter template or guided tutorial would help new users.
- macOS Gatekeeper blocks the app on launch with a malware warning because the binary is unsigned. This is off-putting for new users and requires manual workarounds in System Settings.
- Connecting beats is not intuitive. The node handles on each beat look draggable (standard in node-based editors like Unreal Blueprints, Node-RED, ComfyUI), but dragging does nothing. Connections are actually set via dropdowns in the Inspector panel, which is not discoverable without guidance.
- No Ink format import. Ink is one of the most popular narrative scripting languages, and there is no way to bring Ink stories in. Twine and Ren'Py are supported, but not Ink.
- The beat inspector can feel overwhelming. There are many parameters for each beat type, and it is not always clear which ones matter versus which are optional.
- No persistent HUD or overlay system. If you want a resource bar or status display that stays on screen across beats, there is no built-in way to do that.
- Documentation gap. The User Guide exists but lacks quick-start examples. A "build your first story in 5 minutes" tutorial would go a long way. Notably, the guide does not explain how to create connections between beats.
- No undo feedback. Undo and redo work, but there is no visual confirmation of what was undone, so you are not sure what changed.
- Beat naming defaults are generic ("InfoText 1", "DialogTree 2"). Prompting the user for a name on creation would make large graphs more navigable.
- The noncommercial license (PolyForm Noncommercial 1.0.0) limits who can adopt the tool. Educational or indie teams that might monetize even modestly would need a separate commercial arrangement.

Summary

ASAPS Modern is an ambitious and capable interactive narrative authoring platform. The visual builder, diverse beat types, and standalone HTML export make it a compelling tool for creating branching stories without code. The AI integration and translation features are genuinely innovative. The main barriers to adoption are the first-time user experience (onboarding, connection UX, unsigned binary) and documentation gaps. Addressing these would make the tool significantly more accessible to a wider audience.